

A Practical Love Publication

Love at Home

Nine best steps for a loving marriage and five things to observe with children's food.
A study edition with explanations.

Bless. Edify. Share. Touch. Serve. Talk. Eat. Play. Sleep.

Practical Love Publications

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About This Study Edition

This study edition brings together two short leaflets. The first is about marriage; the second is about feeding children. At first they may seem to belong to different subjects, but they share one theme: love at home. Love in a home is not proved mainly by big celebrations or expensive gifts. It shows itself in daily, ordinary things – a kind word before work, a meal eaten together, a hand held in a hard moment, a plate of food prepared with thought for the child who will eat it.

What you are reading

Throughout this booklet you will see boxed text marked “From the original leaflet”. That text is the leaflet’s wording as printed, with spelling and punctuation lightly corrected. Everything else – the explanations, Scripture notes, practical steps and questions – is study notes prepared by Practical Love Publications to explain and apply the teaching. The notes are not the original author’s own words, and they should not be quoted as if they were.

The first leaflet, “The Marriage Desserts: Best Steps”, was written by Rev. Dr. Moses Remi Owioye, the founder of Practical Love Publications. The second leaflet, “Things to Observe with Children’s Food”, carries no printed author’s name, so this edition presents it without attributing it to anyone.

The two leaflets

The first leaflet opens with this heading:

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

THE MARRIAGE DESSERTS
BEST STEPS

The second leaflet opens with this heading:

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

THINGS TO OBSERVE WITH CHILDREN’S FOOD

How to use this study edition

- **Personal reading.** Read one section slowly, look up the Bible passages in your own Bible, and write down one thing you will do differently this week.
- **Family devotion.** Husband and wife – together with older children for the sections on food – can read a section after the evening meal, talk about it and then pray about what you have read.
- **House fellowship or church study group.** A leader can read the leaflet text aloud, ask members to read the Scriptures, summarise the notes in their own words and use the questions for discussion.

- **One section per sitting.** Each section is written to stand on its own. Do not rush. It is better to practise one step well than to read all nine in one evening and forget them by morning.

Scripture quotations in the notes are from the King James Version. Where the older English of that translation may be unfamiliar – words such as “railing”, “defraud” or “pulse” – the notes explain the meaning in plain words.

An overview of the message

The first part of this booklet follows the nine “best steps” for a loving marriage. Their first letters spell BEST STEPS: Bless, Edify, Share, Touch, Serve, Talk, Eat, Play and Sleep. Some steps concern the words spouses speak, some the life they share, some the affection of their bodies and some their walk with God. A closing marriage section, “Putting the Best Steps into Practice”, gathers the steps into a weekly check-up, speaks about seeking help when a marriage is struggling, and states clearly that love at home never means enduring violence or abuse.

The second part turns to the children at the table. The leaflet lists five things to observe: food should look nice, smell nice and taste nice, it should be nutritious, and children should be given food they like to eat. The notes explain these points with ordinary Nigerian foods, simple hygiene and general guidance for babies and small children. That guidance is general and is not a substitute for the advice of a doctor, nurse or other health worker.

If you want to go further on family life, the companion publication “Raising Loving Families in Nigeria” may be read alongside this booklet.

Love at home is not only felt; it is practised in small things, day after day.

The Marriage Desserts: Best Steps

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

THE MARRIAGE DESSERTS

BEST STEPS

B – Bless your partner always.

E – Edify your partner.

S – Share your joy and sorrow.

T – Touch one another physically.

S – Serve God together.

T – Talk to each other and talk to God personally.

E – Eat together.

P – Play together and pray together.

S – Sleep together.

By Rev. Dr. Moses Remi Owoeye

Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh.

Genesis 2:24 (KJV)

Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it; ... Nevertheless let every one of you in particular so love his wife even as himself; and the wife see that she reverence her husband.

Ephesians 5:25, 33 (KJV)

Why call them “desserts”?

A dessert is the sweet dish that comes at the end of a meal – fruit, a pudding, something that leaves a pleasant taste in the mouth. The leaflet borrows this picture for marriage. The “main meal” of marriage is the covenant itself: a man and a woman joined before God and committed to one another for life. But a marriage can keep its outward form while losing its sweetness. The couple still share a house, still pay the bills and still attend church, yet the home feels cold. The nine steps in this leaflet are the things that bring the sweetness back.

It would be a mistake, however, to think of these desserts as optional extras that only rich or unusually romantic couples can afford. In marriage, the sweet things are part of what keeps love alive. A husband and wife who never bless one another, never eat together, never laugh together and never pray together are starving their marriage, even if every duty is being done. Notice too that almost none of the nine steps costs money. They cost attention, humility and time.

The BEST STEPS pattern

The first letters of the nine lines spell BEST STEPS. This makes the teaching easy to remember and easy to pass on to others. The word “steps” is also important. Nobody climbs a staircase in one jump. A good marriage is not built by one grand gesture on an anniversary but by many small steps taken again and again: a word of thanks today, a shared meal tomorrow, a prayer together on Sunday night.

It helps to see how the nine steps fit together. Between them they touch every part of married life:

- **Words:** bless your partner, edify your partner, talk to each other.
- **Shared life:** share your joy and sorrow, eat together, play together.
- **Bodily affection:** touch one another, sleep together.
- **Life with God:** serve God together, talk to God personally, pray together.

A marriage that is strong in one area and neglected in others will feel the lack. Some couples talk well but rarely show affection; some share a bed but never share their worries; some serve faithfully in church but never play or laugh at home. Taken together, the nine steps call couples to care for the whole relationship.

Marriage is a covenant

Genesis 2:24 is the foundation of the Bible's teaching on marriage, and Jesus himself quoted it (Matthew 19:4-6). It speaks of three movements. First, a man shall **leave** his father and mother. In Nigeria, where family ties are deep and precious, this does not mean abandoning or dishonouring parents. It means that a new household has been formed, and the husband and wife now owe their first human loyalty to each other rather than to the families they came from. Second, he shall **cleave** to his wife – hold on to her closely and faithfully. Third, the two shall become **one flesh**, a union of body, life and purpose.

The prophet Malachi describes a wife as “the wife of thy covenant” and says that the LORD has been witness between a man and the wife of his youth (Malachi 2:14). A covenant is more than a contract. A contract says, “I will do my part if you do yours.” A covenant says, “I bind myself to you before God.” The BEST STEPS are how a covenant is lived out on ordinary days.

Ephesians 5 gives the pattern for that covenant love. Husbands are to love their wives “even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it” – a love that serves, protects and sacrifices rather than dominates. Wives are called to reverence, or respect, their husbands. The whole passage is introduced by a call to all believers: “Submitting yourselves one to another in the fear of God” (Ephesians 5:21). Each of the nine steps is a practical way of giving yourself for your partner's good.

Many Nigerian families spend a great deal of money, time and energy on the wedding ceremony itself. That day is important, but it lasts only a day. The BEST STEPS belong to the thousands of ordinary days that follow, where a marriage is really made.

Practical steps

- Write the nine BEST STEPS on a card and place it where you will both see it – on the bedroom mirror or inside your Bible.
- Ask your spouse, “Which of these nine steps would make you feel most loved this month?” Listen to the answer without arguing.
- Choose one step to practise deliberately this week, and another to practise next week.
- Thank God for the gift of your marriage, whatever its present condition, and ask him for grace to take the next step.

Questions for reflection

1. What difference does it make to see marriage as a covenant and not only a contract?

2. In your own marriage, or in marriages you have observed, which of the “desserts” is most often missing?
3. How can a couple honour their parents and extended family while still “leaving” to form a new household?
4. Why do you think the leaflet speaks of “steps” rather than one single secret for a happy marriage?

A good marriage is built step by step, and most of the steps cost love rather than money.

B – Bless your partner always

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

B – Bless your partner always.

Likewise, ye husbands, dwell with them according to knowledge, giving honour unto the wife, as unto the weaker vessel, and as being heirs together of the grace of life; that your prayers be not hindered. Finally, be ye all of one mind, having compassion one of another, love as brethren, be pitiful, be courteous: Not rendering evil for evil, or railing for railing: but contrariwise blessing; knowing that ye are thereunto called, that ye should inherit a blessing.

1 Peter 3:7-9 (KJV)

The LORD bless thee, and keep thee: The LORD make his face shine upon thee, and be gracious unto thee: The LORD lift up his countenance upon thee, and give thee peace.

Numbers 6:24-26 (KJV)

What it means to bless

To bless someone is to speak good over them, to wish them good and to ask God to do them good. In Scripture, blessing is not empty politeness. Words carry weight: “Death and life are in the power of the tongue” (Proverbs 18:21). Across many Nigerian cultures people understand this instinctively. The words of parents and elders are taken seriously, and a blessing spoken at a wedding or naming ceremony is received with a loud “Amen”. This step invites husbands and wives to carry that same seriousness into everyday life, and to bless each other not only at ceremonies but “always”.

Numbers 6:24-26 records the blessing that the LORD gave Aaron and his sons to speak over Israel. It asks that God would keep his people, make his face shine upon them, be gracious to them and give them peace. A husband or wife can pray these same words over a partner. There are few more loving things you can say to your spouse than, “The LORD bless you, and keep you.”

Blessing when you have been wronged

1 Peter 3 speaks directly to married life. Verses 1 to 6 address wives, and verse 7 addresses husbands, telling them to live with their wives “according to knowledge” – with understanding and consideration – and to give them honour. The phrase “the weaker vessel” does not mean that a wife is of lesser worth. The same verse calls husband and wife “heirs together of the grace of life”, equal sharers in God’s salvation. The husband is warned that if he fails to honour his wife, his own prayers will be hindered. How a man treats his wife affects his relationship with God.

Verse 9 then gives a rule for all believers: do not render “evil for evil, or railing for railing: but contrariwise blessing”. Railing means abusive, insulting speech, and “contrariwise” means “on the contrary”. When your partner speaks sharply, the natural response is to answer sharply. Peter calls believers to do the opposite and answer insult with blessing. This is not weakness. It is the strength of someone who follows Christ, who “when he was reviled, reviled not again” (1 Peter 2:23).

Three ways to bless

With words. Tell your spouse specifically what you appreciate. “Thank you for handling the children’s school matter so patiently” means far more than a vague “You are trying.” Proverbs 31:28 pictures a household where the children call their mother blessed, and “her husband also, and he praiseth her”. Wives too can bless husbands with words of respect and appreciation, which many men rarely hear.

With prayer. Pray for your partner by name – for their health, their work, their journeys and their walk with God. When your spouse leaves for work or travels, place a hand on their shoulder and speak a short blessing. Children who see this learn what a godly home looks like.

With gratitude. Thank your partner in front of others: before the children, before in-laws, among friends and, where it is fitting, in church. Public thanks honours a spouse; public complaint shames them. Do not wait for an anniversary or a birthday to say what your partner means to you.

Never curse your spouse in anger

James 3:10 observes that blessing and cursing can come out of the same mouth, and says plainly, “these things ought not so to be.” In a heated quarrel, some spouses say things they would never say calmly: that the partner is useless, that marrying them was a mistake, or even words wishing them harm. Such words wound deeply and are remembered for years. They also teach children that cruel speech is normal. If you have spoken like this, do not excuse it as “just anger”. Go to God in repentance, go to your spouse and ask for forgiveness, and ask the Lord to guard your mouth, as the psalmist prayed: “Set a watch, O LORD, before my mouth; keep the door of my lips” (Psalm 141:3).

Practical steps

- Every day this week, tell your partner one specific thing you appreciate about them.
- Before your spouse leaves home, speak a short blessing, such as the words of Numbers 6:24-26.

- Thank your spouse publicly at least once this month, in the hearing of your children or family.
- Agree together that certain words – curses, insults and threats of divorce – will never be used in your home, even in anger.
- If harsh words have been spoken, apologise plainly without adding “but you also...”.

Questions for reflection

1. When did your partner last hear you speak well of them in front of other people?
2. Why do you think Peter links a husband’s treatment of his wife with the answering of his prayers?
3. What makes it hard to answer an insult with a blessing, and where can you find the strength to do so?
4. Which words or habits of speech need to be removed from your home?

Speak over your partner the good you want God to do in their life.

E – Edify your partner

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

E – Edify your partner.

Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth, but that which is good to the use of edifying, that it may minister grace unto the hearers.

Ephesians 4:29 (KJV)

Wherefore comfort yourselves together, and edify one another, even as also ye do.

1 Thessalonians 5:11 (KJV)

Building, not tearing down

To edify means to build up. The word comes from the idea of building a house. Every day, husbands and wives are either adding bricks to each other’s lives or pulling bricks out. Proverbs 14:1 says, “Every wise woman buildeth her house: but the foolish plucketh it down with her hands.” The same principle applies to husbands. A home can be pulled down slowly by constant criticism, sarcasm and comparison with other people’s spouses, even while the house of blocks and cement still stands.

Ephesians 4:29 gives a simple test for speech: is it “good to the use of edifying”? Does it “minister grace unto the hearers”? Corrupt communication is not only dirty language; the word describes anything rotten, speech that spoils rather than strengthens. Before you speak to your spouse, especially about a fault, you can ask: will these words help my partner become better, or will they only make me feel better for having

said them?

Correction still has a place in marriage. Edifying does not mean pretending that everything is fine. But there is a difference between a builder who points out a crack so that it can be repaired and a person who kicks the wall. Correct gently, privately and at the right time, and always alongside genuine encouragement.

No mocking in front of others

One of the quickest ways to tear down a partner is to mock them in front of others. It may be a “joke” about a wife’s cooking in front of visitors, a complaint about a husband’s income before his in-laws, or a sarcastic comment in front of the children. Mockery in public tells your spouse that they are not safe with you. It tempts relatives to take sides, and it can damage your partner’s standing with the children, who begin to copy the disrespect they hear.

Jesus taught that when someone wrongs you, you should first speak to that person alone (Matthew 18:15). That wisdom fits marriage well. Settle your complaints between the two of you. If you need help, go together to a trusted pastor or counsellor rather than airing your partner’s faults at family gatherings or on social media.

Encourage your partner’s growth

To edify your partner is also to help them grow into all that God has made them to be. A wife may want to complete her education, learn a trade or start a business. A husband may be discovering a gift for teaching or a desire to serve in a particular ministry. Sadly, some spouses feel threatened when their partner advances, and they discourage or quietly block that progress. Scripture calls for the opposite attitude: “in honour preferring one another” (Romans 12:10), with each person looking “on the things of others” and not only on their own (Philippians 2:4).

Encouragement can be very practical. It may mean taking on more of the childcare while your wife attends evening classes, adjusting the family budget so your husband can take a professional course, or simply listening while your spouse rehearses a presentation. When one partner grows, the whole household benefits.

Edifying in hard seasons

Every marriage passes through seasons that test a person’s sense of worth: the loss of a job, a failed business, a long illness, or the pain of waiting for children. In such seasons, people around the couple sometimes add pressure or blame. A husband or wife who edifies stands beside the partner and says, in word and action, “You are still valued. We will face this together.” Hebrews 10:24 asks believers to “consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works” – to think carefully about how to stir each other up to love. In marriage, that means studying your partner and learning what strengthens them.

Practical steps

- Notice one of your partner's strengths this week and tell them about it.
- Make a firm rule never to mock or belittle your spouse in front of children, in-laws, friends or on social media.
- When correction is needed, speak privately and calmly, and include encouragement.
- Ask your partner, "Is there something you have wanted to learn or achieve that I can help you with?"
- Pray for your spouse's gifts to be used fully for God's glory.

Questions for reflection

1. What is the difference between correcting your partner and tearing them down?
2. How do children learn respect or disrespect from the way their parents speak about each other?
3. Is there any area where you have felt threatened by your partner's progress? Why?
4. What would it look like for you to "consider" your spouse this week in the sense of Hebrews 10:24?

Every word to your partner either adds a brick or removes one.

S – Share your joy and sorrow

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

S – Share your joy and sorrow.

Rejoice with them that do rejoice, and weep with them that weep.

Romans 12:15 (KJV)

Bear ye one another's burdens, and so fulfil the law of Christ.

Galatians 6:2 (KJV)

Two are better than one; because they have a good reward for their labour. For if they fall, the one will lift up his fellow: but woe to him that is alone when he falleth; for he hath not another to help him up.

Ecclesiastes 4:9-10 (KJV)

Two are better than one

Ecclesiastes 4 describes the value of companionship. Two can achieve more than one, and when one falls the other can lift him up. The passage goes on to say that "a threefold cord is not quickly broken" (Ecclesiastes 4:12). Many Christian teachers apply that picture to a husband and wife bound together

with God as the third strand. But the benefit of two only comes when they actually share their lives. A husband and wife can live under one roof and still be lonely if each carries their joys and burdens alone.

Sharing joy

Romans 12:15 begins with rejoicing. It can be surprisingly hard to share a partner's joy fully. A wife's promotion may stir a husband's insecurity; a husband's success may come at a time when his wife feels overlooked. Sometimes good news is shared with friends or colleagues first, and the spouse hears it last. Make your partner the first person to know about your answered prayers, your breakthroughs and your children's achievements. Celebrate each other's victories as your own – because in a one-flesh marriage, they are.

Sharing sorrow

“Weep with them that weep.” Sorrow comes to every home: the death of a parent, the loss of a pregnancy, a disappointment at work, a frightening diagnosis. Some people, especially men, have been taught that showing grief is weakness, and they withdraw into silence. Others are so busy trying to fix the problem that they do not stop to comfort. Sharing sorrow means allowing your partner to see your pain, and being present when they are in pain, even when you have no solution to offer. Galatians 6:2 calls this bearing “one another's burdens”, and says that in doing so we fulfil the law of Christ.

Honesty about money

Few things strain marriages more than deception about money: secret debts, loans taken without the partner's knowledge, money quietly sent to relatives behind a spouse's back, or lies about income and spending. Couples may manage their money in different ways – some pool everything, while others keep separate accounts with agreed shared responsibilities. Many husbands and wives also keep some personal savings, perhaps in their own bank account or in a thrift or savings group such as esusu or ajo, and that is not wrong in itself. The Bible does not prescribe one method. What it does require is truthfulness: “Wherefore putting away lying, speak every man truth with his neighbour: for we are members one of another” (Ephesians 4:25). If husband and wife are members of one another, deception about money – hidden debts, loans taken in secret, or lies about income and spending – breaks the trust this verse calls for.

Sharing about money includes sharing pressure. If income has dropped, if rent is due and there is no money, or if a business is struggling, tell your partner early. It is far easier to face hardship together with a plan than to have a crisis discovered suddenly.

Extended family matters

In Nigerian society, marriage joins not only two people but two families. Relatives may ask for help with school fees, hospital bills or ceremonies, and parents may have expectations about visits, support or

where the couple should live. Honouring father and mother is a command of God (Exodus 20:12), and caring for family is good. But decisions about family requests should be made together, not behind a spouse's back. When a husband and wife agree on how they will respond to relatives, they protect both their marriage and their relationships with the wider family.

Wise sharing

Sharing does not mean that every passing thought must be spoken the moment it arises, or that a partner may never have a quiet moment alone. It means there are no locked rooms in the marriage – no areas of life deliberately hidden from each other. It also means guarding what your partner shares with you. What your spouse tells you in trust should not become a story told to your friends, your relatives or your prayer group. Where a partner is controlling, threatening or violent, keeping yourself and your children safe comes first; see “Love never means enduring violence” in the section “Putting the Best Steps into Practice”.

Practical steps

- Set aside a short time at the end of each day to tell each other the best and the hardest parts of your day.
- Make your spouse the first to hear your good news.
- Agree on a simple, honest way to discuss income, spending, savings and debts, and review it together regularly.
- Decide together how you will respond to financial requests from relatives.
- Keep your partner's confidences private.

Questions for reflection

1. Is it easier for you to share joy or to share sorrow with your partner? Why?
2. Are there financial matters you have not been open about? What first step towards honesty can you take?
3. How can a couple support relatives generously without allowing family pressures to divide them?
4. What does it mean in practice to bear your partner's burdens?

In a one-flesh marriage, there should be no locked rooms.

T – Touch one another physically

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

T – Touch one another physically.

His left hand is under my head, and his right hand doth embrace me.

Song of Solomon 2:6 (KJV)

Husbands, love your wives, and be not bitter against them.

Colossians 3:19 (KJV)

Touch speaks

Touch is a language. A hand on the shoulder can say, “I am with you.” Holding hands can say, “We belong together.” An embrace when one partner returns home can say, “I am glad you are back.” Long before a baby understands words, it is comforted by being held. Adults never outgrow that need. This step is a reminder that physical affection is part of how love is given and received.

In the Gospels, Jesus often touched people as he healed them. When a man with leprosy – someone others would have avoided – came to him, Jesus, “moved with compassion, put forth his hand, and touched him” (Mark 1:41). His touch expressed acceptance as well as power. In marriage, gentle touch tells your partner that they are accepted, wanted and safe.

Affection is not shameful

The Song of Solomon is part of God’s Word, and it celebrates the love between a bride and her beloved with great warmth. Chapter 2 verse 6 pictures the tenderness of an embrace. Christians sometimes feel embarrassed about affection, as if spiritual people should be above such things. Scripture does not share that embarrassment. Within marriage, affection is good and God-given.

Many couples are affectionate in the early years and then slowly stop. Children arrive, work becomes demanding, and husband and wife begin to relate more like business partners managing a household than like lovers. The leaflet’s simple instruction is a call to keep reaching out to each other. In many Nigerian communities, open displays of affection in public are considered improper, and couples may rightly be modest outside the home. But modesty in public is no reason for coldness in private. Hold hands as you pray at home, sit close while you talk, embrace when you greet each other, and let your children see that their parents love each other.

Touch must be gentle and welcome

Colossians 3:19 tells husbands to love their wives and not to be bitter against them. Bitterness makes a person harsh, and harshness spoils touch. Loving touch is always gentle, respectful and welcome.

Spouses differ: one may enjoy frequent hugs, while another prefers quieter signs of affection. One may be exhausted after a long day or unwell. Learning what your partner finds comforting, and respecting their wishes, is part of dwelling with them “according to knowledge” (1 Peter 3:7).

Caring touch matters through every season of life: during pregnancy and after childbirth, in illness, in grief and in old age. Rubbing a tired partner’s shoulders, holding a hand beside a hospital bed, or steadying an elderly spouse as they walk are all ways of keeping this step.

Never violent

This must be said plainly: the hand that is meant to comfort must never be used to hurt. Slapping, pushing, beating, kicking, pulling hair, throwing objects or using force of any kind against a spouse is never love, and it is never an acceptable way of settling a quarrel or “correcting” a partner. No tradition, family pressure or misreading of Scripture makes it right. Love – which the King James Version calls “charity” – “suffereth long, and is kind” and “is not easily provoked” (1 Corinthians 13:4-5). Anyone who is being hurt at home should seek safety and help; the section “Putting the Best Steps into Practice” speaks about this more fully.

Practical steps

- Greet your partner with an embrace when one of you leaves or returns home.
- Hold hands when you pray together.
- Ask your spouse what kinds of affection make them feel most loved, and what they do not enjoy.
- Offer caring touch when your partner is tired, sick or sad.
- If anger ever tempts you towards physical harm, walk away, calm down and seek help at once.

Questions for reflection

1. What does your partner’s touch communicate to you?
2. Why do many couples become less affectionate after some years of marriage, and how can this be reversed?
3. How can a couple show modesty in public without becoming cold in private?
4. What does 1 Corinthians 13:4-5 teach about the kind of touch that belongs in a Christian home?

The hand that is meant to comfort must never be used to hurt.

S – Serve God together

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

S – Serve God together.

And if it seem evil unto you to serve the LORD, choose you this day whom ye will serve; whether the gods which your fathers served that were on the other side of the flood, or the gods of the Amorites, in whose land ye dwell: but as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD.

Joshua 24:15 (KJV)

And found a certain Jew named Aquila, born in Pontus, lately come from Italy, with his wife Priscilla; (because that Claudius had commanded all Jews to depart from Rome:) and came unto them. And because he was of the same craft, he abode with them, and wrought: for by their occupation they were tentmakers. ... And he began to speak boldly in the synagogue: whom when Aquila and Priscilla had heard, they took him unto them, and expounded unto him the way of God more perfectly.

Acts 18:2-3, 26 (KJV)

Greet Priscilla and Aquila my helpers in Christ Jesus: Who have for my life laid down their own necks: unto whom not only I give thanks, but also all the churches of the Gentiles.

Romans 16:3-4 (KJV)

A household decision

Joshua spoke these words near the end of his life, when he called Israel to choose whom they would serve. He did not speak only for himself. He said, “as for me and my house.” A family’s spiritual direction does not happen by accident. It is decided, and then lived out day by day. A husband and wife who agree, “In this home, we will serve the LORD,” have laid a foundation that affects everything else – how they spend money, how they treat each other, how they raise their children and how they respond to trouble.

Priscilla and Aquila

The New Testament gives a fine example of a couple who served God together. Aquila, a Jew born in Pontus, and his wife Priscilla had recently come from Italy, because the emperor Claudius “had commanded all Jews to depart from Rome” (Acts 18:2). In Corinth they met the apostle Paul, and because they shared his trade of tentmaking, he lived and worked with them (Acts 18:2-3). Their home became a place of hospitality for a servant of God.

Later, in Ephesus, they heard a gifted preacher named Apollos, who was eloquent and fervent but whose understanding was incomplete. They did not criticise him publicly. They “took him unto them, and expounded unto him the way of God more perfectly” (Acts 18:26). Together, as a couple, they quietly

helped a preacher to grow. Paul later called them his “helpers in Christ Jesus” and said they had risked their own lives for him (Romans 16:3-4). He also greeted “the church that is in their house” (Romans 16:5; see also 1 Corinthians 16:19).

Notice several things about this couple. Whenever the New Testament mentions this couple, their names appear together (Acts 18:2, 18, 26; Romans 16:3; 1 Corinthians 16:19; 2 Timothy 4:19). Their work, their home and their ministry were woven into one shared life. They served faithfully in more than one city as life moved them. And their service flowed out of their home rather than competing with it.

Ways to serve God together

- **A family altar.** Set a regular time – morning or evening – when the household gathers to read a short Bible passage, sing and pray. It need not be long to be faithful.
- **Worship together.** Wherever possible, attend services together, and talk about what you heard on the way home.
- **Give together.** Decide together about tithes, offerings and help for people in need, so that giving becomes a shared act of worship rather than a source of quarrels.
- **Use your home.** Open your home for hospitality, a house fellowship or the encouragement of younger couples, as Priscilla and Aquila did.
- **Serve side by side.** Look for an area of church or community service where you can both be involved, or support one another’s service with prayer and practical help.

When only one spouse is walking with God

Not every reader is married to someone who shares their faith. Scripture speaks tenderly to this situation. 1 Peter 3:1-2 tells believing wives that a husband who does not obey the word may be won “without the word” by his wife’s godly conduct, and 1 Corinthians 7:12-14 tells believers not to put away an unbelieving spouse who is content to remain in the marriage. If this is your situation, serve God faithfully yourself, pray for your partner, and let your love and good character speak more loudly than pressure or preaching.

Do not let church activity replace your family

There is a danger on the other side too. Some Christians are in church almost every evening – rehearsals, vigils, meetings and programmes – while their spouse and children hardly see them. They may be praised in church while their home quietly suffers. Scripture treats the care of one’s own household as part of Christian faithfulness. One of the qualifications for church leadership is that a man “ruleth well his own house” (1 Timothy 3:4), and Paul explains why: “if a man know not how to rule his own house, how shall he take care of the church of God?” (1 Timothy 3:5). Serving God together should draw a family closer, not pull it apart. Couples should agree on a healthy balance between church commitments and protected

family time.

Practical steps

- This week, choose a time and place for family devotion, and decide who will read, who will lead a song and who will pray.
- On the next payday, sit down together and agree on your tithe, your offerings and one person or need you will help this month.
- Within the next month, invite one person or family – a new church member, a lonely neighbour or a younger couple – to share a meal in your home.
- Write down every church meeting each of you attends in a normal week, and agree which evenings will be kept free for the family.

Questions for reflection

1. What would it mean in practice for your household to say, “as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD”?
2. What do you learn from the way Priscilla and Aquila helped Apollos?
3. How can a believer serve God faithfully when their spouse does not yet share their faith?
4. Are there signs that church activity is taking time that belongs to your family? What should change?

Service to God should flow out of the home, not compete with it.

T – Talk to each other and talk to God personally

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

T – Talk to each other and talk to God personally.

Wherefore, my beloved brethren, let every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath:

James 1:19 (KJV)

A soft answer turneth away wrath: but grievous words stir up anger.

Proverbs 15:1 (KJV)

Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath:

Ephesians 4:26 (KJV)

But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.

Two kinds of talking

This step joins two things that belong together. Husband and wife must talk to each other, and each must also talk to God personally. A marriage in which the couple communicate well but neither prays lacks spiritual strength. A marriage in which both pray fervently but hardly speak to each other lacks closeness. The leaflet asks for both.

Talking to each other

Many couples talk every day, but only about practical matters: school fees, fuel, the electricity bill, what to cook and who will collect the children. Those conversations are necessary, but they are not enough. Real talking includes questions such as “How are you really?”, “What is worrying you?” and “What made you happy today?” A short daily check-in, when both partners give each other full attention, can prevent many misunderstandings from growing into serious conflicts.

Swift to hear

James 1:19 puts listening first: “swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath.” Much conflict in marriage comes not from what was said but from what was not heard. Listening well means putting down the phone, turning towards your partner, allowing them to finish without interrupting, and checking that you have understood: “Are you saying that you felt ignored when I made that decision without you?” When a person feels heard, their anger often softens even before a solution is found.

When you disagree

Disagreements are normal in every marriage; what matters is how they are handled. Proverbs 15:1 teaches that a soft answer turns away wrath, while grievous – that is, painful and wounding – words stir up anger. Speak about the problem, not about your partner’s character. Say, “I was hurt when you came home late without calling,” rather than, “You never care about anybody but yourself.” Avoid words such as “always” and “never”. Choose your moment wisely: not when one of you is very tired or hungry, and not in front of the children.

Ephesians 4:26 recognises that anger will come, but it warns, “let not the sun go down upon your wrath.” Not every disagreement can be fully solved before bedtime. Sometimes a couple must agree to continue a discussion the next day. But they can still lay down their anger, pray together and go to sleep reconciled. The next verse adds, “Neither give place to the devil” (Ephesians 4:27). Anger carried from one day to the next hardens into resentment, and resentment gives the enemy room to work.

Talking to God personally

The leaflet adds the word “personally”. Your spouse cannot pray in place of your own prayers, and your partner’s faith cannot replace your own relationship with God. In Matthew 6:5-6 Jesus warned against praying in order to be seen by others, and invited his followers to pray to the Father in secret. Each husband and each wife needs a private place and time to read Scripture, confess sin, receive God’s peace and bring their needs to him. A spouse who is spiritually nourished in private brings patience, humility and wisdom into the marriage.

This matters especially when marriage is difficult. When you feel unable to speak calmly to your partner, you can still speak honestly to God. Many quarrels are softened when one partner first pours out their frustration before the Lord instead of pouring it on their spouse.

Praying for each other

Personal prayer should include your partner. James 5:16 tells believers to “pray one for another”. Pray for your spouse’s work, health, protection, decisions and walk with God. Pray about their temptations and struggles. It is very difficult to remain bitter towards someone you are sincerely praying for every day.

Practical steps

- Have a short daily check-in with your partner, with phones and television switched off.
- In your next disagreement, repeat back what your partner has said before giving your own view.
- Agree on a signal either of you can use to pause an argument that is becoming heated, and a time to return to it.
- Do not go to sleep without speaking peace to each other, even if the matter is not fully settled.
- Keep a personal daily time with God, and pray for your spouse by name.

Questions for reflection

1. Beyond household business, what did you and your partner last talk about deeply?
2. Which part of James 1:19 do you find most difficult – being swift to hear, slow to speak or slow to wrath?
3. How can a couple obey Ephesians 4:26 when a problem cannot be solved in one evening?
4. Why is a personal relationship with God important even for a couple who pray together?

Speak to your partner with a soft answer, and speak to God about your partner every day.

E – Eat together

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

E – Eat together.

And they, continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, did eat their meat with gladness and singleness of heart,

Acts 2:46 (KJV)

And it came to pass, as he sat at meat with them, he took bread, and blessed it, and brake, and gave to them. And their eyes were opened, and they knew him; and he vanished out of their sight.

Luke 24:30-31 (KJV)

More than food

In Scripture, eating together is often a sign of fellowship. The first believers in Jerusalem broke bread from house to house and ate their food “with gladness and singleness of heart” (Acts 2:46). In the older English of the King James Version, “meat” simply means food. After his resurrection, Jesus walked with two disciples to Emmaus, and it was at the table, as he took bread, blessed it and broke it, that their eyes were opened and they recognised him (Luke 24:30-31). On another occasion the risen Lord prepared a meal of fish and bread by the lakeside and invited his tired disciples, “Come and dine” (John 21:12).

These passages show that the table is a place where relationships are strengthened and where God is often at work. Psalm 128:3 pictures a blessed home with children “like olive plants round about thy table”. When a husband and wife – and their children – regularly eat together, they create a daily meeting place for the family.

A place of thanksgiving

Begin shared meals with thanks to God. Scripture teaches that the food God created is good and is to be received with thanksgiving, sanctified by the word of God and prayer (1 Timothy 4:4-5). Giving thanks together reminds everyone at the table that daily bread comes from the Father, and it teaches children gratitude. Let different members of the family take turns to pray, including the children.

A place of conversation

A meal eaten in silence while everyone watches television or scrolls through their phone is hardly a shared meal. Where possible, switch off the television and put phones aside. Ask each person to share something about their day. Avoid turning the table into a courtroom where quarrels are settled or children are scolded. Proverbs 17:1 says, “Better is a dry morsel, and quietness therewith, than an house full of sacrifices with strife.” The “sacrifices” were the meat of offerings, often eaten at a feast, so the picture is of a house full of rich food where there is quarrelling. A simple meal eaten in peace can do more for a

family than an expensive one eaten in tension.

Honour the one who cooked

Cooking for a family takes time, energy and planning, often after a long day of work or trading. The one who cooked – whether wife, husband, older child or relative – deserves to be thanked, so say so at the table. If something is not to your taste, mention it kindly and privately, not with complaints in front of everyone. Husbands and children can honour the cook in practical ways too: helping to set the table, serving, washing plates and clearing up.

Nigerian realities

It would be unrealistic to pretend that every family can sit down together for every meal. Many parents leave home very early to beat the traffic and return late at night. Some work shifts or night duty, some travel for business, and some trade in markets from dawn to dusk. Even Jesus and his disciples knew days so busy that “they had no leisure so much as to eat” (Mark 6:31).

The goal is not perfection but intention. Aim for at least some shared meals each week. It might be breakfast on Saturday morning, lunch after church on Sunday, or a cup of tea together when a spouse returns from a late shift. Guard these times as you would guard an important appointment. Couples without children, or whose children have grown up and left home, need this step just as much: a meal shared by two people is still a meeting of hearts.

An open table

The Bible also encourages hospitality: “Use hospitality one to another without grudging” (1 Peter 4:9). A family that eats together can sometimes invite others to the table – a lonely neighbour, a student far from home, a new church member. Such hospitality blesses others and teaches children generosity. It should be planned together by husband and wife, so that it strengthens the family rather than overwhelming it.

Practical steps

- Look at your family’s weekly timetable and choose a few meals you can regularly share.
- Switch off the television and put phones away during those meals.
- Take turns giving thanks before eating.
- Thank the person who prepared the food, every time.
- Share the work of serving and clearing up.

Questions for reflection

1. What usually happens at mealtimes in your home? Is the table a place of fellowship?

2. Why do you think Jesus so often taught and revealed himself around meals?
3. What prevents your family from eating together, and what small change could help?
4. How can you show honour to the person who cooks in your home?

A simple meal shared in peace feeds the heart as well as the body.

P – Play together and pray together

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

P – Play together and pray together.

A merry heart doeth good like a medicine: but a broken spirit drieth the bones.

Proverbs 17:22 (KJV)

Live joyfully with the wife whom thou lovest all the days of the life of thy vanity, which he hath given thee under the sun, all the days of thy vanity: for that is thy portion in this life, and in thy labour which thou takest under the sun.

Ecclesiastes 9:9 (KJV)

Let thy fountain be blessed: and rejoice with the wife of thy youth.

Proverbs 5:18 (KJV)

Friends as well as spouses

In the Song of Solomon, the bride describes her husband with two phrases: “This is my beloved, and this is my friend” (Song of Solomon 5:16). A strong marriage is a deep friendship. Friends enjoy each other’s company, share jokes, relax together and look forward to being together. Many couples were friends during courtship – they talked for hours, went out together and laughed easily – but after marriage, responsibilities slowly crowded out the friendship. This step calls couples to rediscover the joy of simply being together.

The medicine of laughter

Proverbs 17:22 says, “A merry heart doeth good like a medicine.” Laughter relieves tension, softens hard days and reminds a couple that they are on the same side. Ecclesiastes 9:9 urges a husband to live joyfully with the wife he loves through all the days of this brief life – “vanity” here means life’s passing, fragile nature – and Proverbs 5:18 calls him to “rejoice with the wife of thy youth”. Joy in marriage is not worldliness; it is obedience.

The Law of Moses even made room for a newly married man to be free from military service and other public duties for a year, so that he could “cheer up his wife which he hath taken” (Deuteronomy 24:5). God cared that a new marriage had time for gladness to take root.

Humour must be kind. Jokes that belittle your partner, especially in front of others, are not play but mockery, as the notes on edifying your partner explain. Laugh together, not at each other.

Play need not be expensive

Playing together does not require money for holidays or fancy restaurants. Consider simple things like these:

- An evening walk around your neighbourhood, where it is safe to do so.
- Board and table games such as ludo, draughts or ayo.
- Cooking a new dish together.
- Watching a wholesome film or listening to music together.
- Looking through your wedding photographs and remembering how you met.
- A picnic in a park, or a visit to a place in your own town you have never been.
- Playing with your children together, and letting them see their parents enjoying each other's company.

Praying together

The leaflet places play and prayer side by side. Jesus promised in Matthew 18:19 that if two agree on earth about anything they ask, it shall be done for them by the Father in heaven. A husband and wife are the most natural pair of praying believers. Praying together unites them in purpose, humbles them before God and brings their shared concerns – children, finances, health and extended family – into God's hands.

Many couples find praying together awkward at first. Start simply. Hold hands, and each pray one or two sentences. Thank God for one thing and ask him for one thing. Take turns leading. Avoid using prayer as a way of preaching at your partner, as in “Lord, touch my wife's stubborn heart.” Pray for your partner's needs, not your complaints about them.

Why play and prayer belong together

Play without prayer can leave a marriage enjoyable but spiritually shallow. Prayer without play can leave it serious but joyless. Together they keep a marriage both warm and holy. The couple who laugh together find it easier to pray together, and the couple who pray together often find more to laugh about.

Practical steps

- Plan one simple, low-cost activity to enjoy together this week.
- Recall a happy memory from your courtship and talk about it.
- Pray together briefly every day, even if only for a few moments before sleeping.
- Let your children see you laughing and praying together.

Questions for reflection

1. Would you describe your spouse as your friend? What would strengthen that friendship?
2. When did you last laugh together, and what caused it?
3. What makes praying together difficult for many couples, and how can those difficulties be overcome?
4. Which simple activity could you and your partner enjoy together this month?

Laugh together and pray together, and your friendship will stay both warm and holy.

S – Sleep together

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

S – Sleep together.

Let the husband render unto the wife due benevolence: and likewise also the wife unto the husband. The wife hath not power of her own body, but the husband: and likewise also the husband hath not power of his own body, but the wife. Defraud ye not one the other, except it be with consent for a time, that ye may give yourselves to fasting and prayer; and come together again, that Satan tempt you not for your incontinency.

1 Corinthians 7:3-5 (KJV)

Marriage is honourable in all, and the bed undefiled: but whoremongers and adulterers God will judge.

Hebrews 13:4 (KJV)

Sharing the bed

The last step speaks about the most private part of married life. At its simplest, “sleep together” means that husband and wife should normally share the same bed. Sharing a bed is a daily sign of unity. It is where many couples talk quietly at the end of the day, pray together, comfort each other and simply rest in each other’s presence. When couples begin sleeping in separate rooms because of quarrels, habit or convenience, emotional distance often follows. There may be good temporary reasons for sleeping apart,

such as serious illness or the demands of a newborn baby, but these should be agreed together and not allowed to become permanent without discussion. If you are being hurt, threatened or forced, your safety comes first. You do not need your partner's agreement to sleep somewhere safe – see “Love never means enduring violence” in the next section.

Intimacy is God's gift

The phrase also refers, with proper modesty, to the physical union of husband and wife. Hebrews 13:4 declares, “Marriage is honourable in all, and the bed undefiled.” Sexual intimacy within marriage is not shameful or unspiritual. It is God's gift, designed to be enjoyed by husband and wife, and it expresses and strengthens the one-flesh union of Genesis 2:24. The same verse warns that God will judge sexual immorality, and so draws a clear boundary: this gift belongs only within marriage, and faithfulness to one's spouse is essential.

Mutual care, never pressure

In 1 Corinthians 7:3-5, Paul uses the phrase “due benevolence” – literally, the goodwill that is owed – to describe the kindness husbands and wives owe each other in intimacy. What is striking is that he speaks with complete equality. The wife does not have power over her own body, but the husband does, and “likewise also” the husband does not have power over his own body, but the wife does. Neither is given the right to use the other selfishly. The passage teaches mutual giving, not one-sided demanding.

This passage must never be twisted to justify pressure or force. Love “seeketh not her own” (1 Corinthians 13:5). Intimacy that is demanded, forced or obtained through threats is not what Scripture describes, and it is a serious wrong, even within marriage. A loving spouse is sensitive to a partner's tiredness, illness, pain, grief or recovery after childbirth, and talks gently about these things instead of making demands.

Not a weapon

Paul also warns, “Defraud ye not one the other.” To defraud means to cheat or deprive. Withholding intimacy as a punishment – to win an argument or to make a partner suffer – turns God's gift into a weapon. Paul speaks of a couple abstaining “with consent for a time”, for a spiritual purpose such as fasting and prayer, and then to come together again so that Satan does not tempt them through lack of self-control (which is what “incontinency” means here). The key words are consent and time: a shared, temporary decision, not a one-sided withdrawal.

This does not take away either spouse's freedom to say no on a particular occasion. Tiredness, illness, pain, grief or fear are not ‘defrauding’, and no husband or wife should be pressured or made to feel guilty into intimacy. What Paul warns against is a deliberate, lasting withdrawal used to punish or control a partner.

What pushes couples apart

Several ordinary things can quietly push a husband and wife apart at night. **Anger** carried to bed makes closeness impossible, which is another reason to heed Ephesians 4:26. **Children** who regularly sleep in the parents' bed long after they need to can leave little room for the couple's own relationship; parents can lovingly help children settle in their own sleeping place in a way suited to their age. **Phones, laptops and television** late into the night can replace conversation and closeness. Consider making the bedroom a place for rest and for each other, not for work or endless scrolling.

When work or travel separates you

Many Nigerian couples are separated for long periods because of work: one spouse posted to another state, working away from home for weeks at a time, trading in another city or living abroad while the other stays at home with the children. Such arrangements are sometimes necessary, but they place real strain on a marriage, and Paul's warning about temptation applies strongly. Couples who live apart must be intentional. Speak regularly by phone or video call, plan visits and reunions, stay honest with each other about loneliness and temptation, avoid situations that invite unfaithfulness, and review together from time to time whether the separation is still wise.

When there are difficulties

Some couples face physical or emotional difficulties with intimacy. There is no shame in this. Pain or health problems should be taken to a qualified doctor, and emotional or relational difficulties can be discussed with a trusted, mature pastor or Christian counsellor who will keep confidence. Silence usually makes such problems worse.

Practical steps

- Protect the habit of sharing a bed, and talk together before making any change to that arrangement – unless your safety is at risk.
- Settle anger before going to sleep, and pray together at bedtime.
- Agree on limits for phones and television in the bedroom.
- Speak openly and kindly with each other about your needs and concerns.
- If work separates you, agree on a plan for regular contact, visits and accountability.

Questions for reflection

These questions are best discussed privately between husband and wife.

1. Why do you think the leaflet places “Sleep together” among the steps to a loving marriage?

2. What does the equality of 1 Corinthians 7:4 teach about how husband and wife should treat each other?
3. What habits or pressures most often push you and your partner apart at night?
4. If you and your spouse live apart for work, what safeguards and plans do you have in place?

Intimacy is God's gift, to be given in love – never taken by force or withheld as punishment.

Putting the Best Steps into Practice

Knowing the nine steps is only the beginning. Jesus said that the wise man, who builds his house upon a rock, is the one who hears his sayings “and doeth them” (Matthew 7:24). This section gathers the BEST STEPS into a simple habit of self-examination, offers words for a couple’s commitment, and speaks about seeking help when a marriage is struggling.

Let us search and try our ways, and turn again to the LORD.

Lamentations 3:40 (KJV)

A weekly BEST STEPS check-up

Once a week – perhaps on a Sunday evening – each spouse can quietly go through these questions. Answer them about yourself, not about your partner.

1. **Bless:** Did I speak blessing, thanks and prayer over my partner this week?
2. **Edify:** Did my words build my partner up? Did I avoid mocking or belittling them?
3. **Share:** Did I share my joys, sorrows and concerns – including money matters – honestly?
4. **Touch:** Did I show gentle and welcome affection?
5. **Serve:** Did we worship, pray or serve God together, without neglecting our home?
6. **Talk:** Did I listen well, answer softly and spend personal time with God?
7. **Eat:** Did we share at least some meals in peace and thanksgiving?
8. **Play and pray:** Did we laugh, relax and pray together?
9. **Sleep:** Did we protect our closeness at night, settling anger and caring for each other?

After going through the questions separately, you may choose to talk about them together. Share where you think you did well and where you want to grow. Resist the temptation to turn the check-up into a list of your partner’s failures. Then choose just one step to focus on in the coming week. Small, steady improvement is better than a burst of effort that soon fades.

A couple's commitment

Some couples find it helpful to make a simple commitment together before God, perhaps on an anniversary or at the start of a new year. You may use or adapt these words, then pray together:

- We will bless each other with our words and prayers, and never curse each other in anger.
- We will build each other up and encourage each other's growth.
- We will share our joys, our sorrows and our resources honestly.
- We will show each other gentle affection, and never use our hands to harm.
- We will serve God together as a household.
- We will listen to each other, and each keep a personal walk with God.
- We will make time to eat together, play together and pray together.
- We will protect our closeness and our faithfulness to each other as God's gift.

Seeking help

Where no counsel is, the people fall: but in the multitude of counsellors there is safety.

Proverbs 11:14 (KJV)

Every marriage needs help at times, and asking for help is a sign of wisdom, not failure. If you and your partner keep returning to the same quarrels, if trust has been broken, or if one of you feels hopeless, speak to a trusted pastor, a mature Christian couple or a qualified counsellor. Choose someone who will keep confidence, listen fairly to both of you and point you to Christ. Do not wait until the marriage is in crisis; many problems are easier to address while they are still small.

Be careful about taking marriage problems to many different people. Well-meaning relatives and friends often hear only one side and can make matters worse by taking sides. The “multitude of counsellors” in Proverbs means wise, godly counsel, not the opinions of everyone who hears about your troubles.

Love never means enduring violence

Hear this clearly: love at home never means enduring violence or abuse. Hitting, beating, choking, threatening, forcing a spouse into intimacy, or controlling someone through fear is not love and has no place in a Christian marriage. Psalm 11:5 says that the soul of the LORD hates the one who loves violence. No husband or wife is required by God to remain in danger, and no child should be left exposed to it.

If you or your children are in danger, seek safety first. Go to trusted people who can protect you, such as family members, friends or church leaders, and contact the proper authorities, including the police. Seek medical care for any injuries. Pastors, counsellors and relatives who hear of abuse should take it seriously, help the person to reach safety, and never send them back into danger or simply tell them to

pray and endure. Seeking safety is not a failure of faith.

Questions for reflection

1. Which of the nine steps is strongest in your marriage, and which needs the most attention?
2. How can a weekly check-up help a couple without becoming a source of blame?
3. Who are the wise and trustworthy people you could approach if your marriage needed help?
4. What should a church do to make sure that people suffering violence at home are protected and supported?

Love at home never means enduring violence or abuse.

Things to Observe with Children's Food

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

THINGS TO OBSERVE WITH CHILDREN'S FOOD

1. Food must LOOK nice.
2. Food must SMELL nice.
3. Food must TASTE nice.
4. Food must be NUTRITIOUS.
5. Give children food they like to eat.

Or what man is there of you, whom if his son ask bread, will he give him a stone? Or if he ask a fish, will he give him a serpent? If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children, how much more shall your Father which is in heaven give good things to them that ask him?

Matthew 7:9-11 (KJV)

But if any provide not for his own, and specially for those of his own house, he hath denied the faith, and is worse than an infidel.

1 Timothy 5:8 (KJV)

She riseth also while it is yet night, and giveth meat to her household, and a portion to her maidens. ... She looketh well to the ways of her household, and eateth not the bread of idleness.

Proverbs 31:15, 27 (KJV)

From the marriage to the table

The second leaflet moves from husband and wife to the children at the table. It may seem a humble subject beside the teaching on marriage, but it belongs in the same study. Love at home is expressed not

only between spouses but also in the everyday care of children. For a young child, one of the clearest signs of being loved is the food placed before them – whether it is prepared with care, served with patience and eaten in a peaceful atmosphere.

The leaflet carries no printed author's name. Its five points are short and practical, and the notes that follow explain them in the light of Scripture and general, widely accepted guidance on feeding children. They are not medical advice. Where a child has a particular health condition, follow the advice of a doctor, nurse or other qualified health worker.

Feeding children is an act of love

In Matthew 7:9-11, Jesus takes it for granted that ordinary parents want to give their children good things. No normal father answers a request for bread by handing over a stone. Jesus uses this everyday truth to teach about the goodness of our heavenly Father, who gives good things to those who ask him. But the picture also honours what parents do. When you prepare good food for your child, you reflect in a small way the generous care of God.

Feeding children well is therefore more than a chore to be finished quickly. The effort a parent makes to prepare food that looks, smells and tastes good, that nourishes the body and that the child can enjoy, is a daily act of love.

Feeding children is stewardship

1 Timothy 5:8 speaks strongly about providing for one's own household, saying that a person who fails to do so "hath denied the faith". Paul is rebuking those who refuse or neglect to care for their own relatives, not parents who are doing their best in hardship. A family struggling to feed its children needs the help and generosity of the church, not condemnation. Children are "an heritage of the LORD" (Psalm 127:3), a gift and a trust from God, and their food is part of that trust. The woman of Proverbs 31 rises early to provide food for her household, and she "looketh well to the ways of her household". She plans ahead and pays attention. That kind of thoughtful planning – knowing what is in the house, what the children need and how the money can be stretched – is part of faithful stewardship.

This responsibility belongs to both parents. In many Nigerian homes, mothers carry most of the work of feeding the children, often while also working or trading. Fathers share the responsibility by providing, by planning together, by helping in the kitchen when they can, and by showing appreciation. Stewardship does not require expensive food. Many nourishing foods are simple, local and affordable.

Habits formed at home

Proverbs 22:6 says, "Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it." This verse is chiefly about moral and spiritual training, but its principle applies to many habits. What a child learns to eat, how they behave at the table, whether they give thanks, and whether they see food as

a gift or as a battleground are all largely shaped at home. Habits formed in childhood often last for many years.

Many children are also fed by grandparents, house helps, nannies, day-care workers or school canteens. Share with them what you want for your child – the kinds of food, how much sugar and salt, and how mealtimes should be handled – so that the child receives consistent care wherever they are.

Practical steps

- Thank God for the provision of food, and ask him for wisdom in feeding your children.
- Plan the week's meals together as parents, taking account of what is affordable and in season.
- Talk with anyone who helps to feed your children about what you want for them.
- Give thanks together as a family before meals, so that children learn to see food as God's gift.

Questions for reflection

1. Why do you think a leaflet on children's food belongs alongside teaching on marriage?
2. How does Matthew 7:9-11 help you see the everyday feeding of children differently?
3. In what practical ways can fathers share in the responsibility of feeding children?
4. What eating habits did you learn at home as a child, and which would you like to pass on?

A plate prepared with care tells a child, "You are loved."

1–3. Food must look, smell and taste nice

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

1. Food must LOOK nice.
2. Food must SMELL nice.
3. Food must TASTE nice.

Better is a dinner of herbs where love is, than a stalled ox and hatred therewith.

Proverbs 15:17 (KJV)

Children eat with their eyes and noses first

The first three points of the leaflet belong together. Before a child tastes anything, they look at it and smell it. A plate that looks dull or messy, or food that smells burnt or stale, may be refused before the first spoonful. Adults respond in a similar way – most of us are drawn to food that looks and smells appetising – but children, who cannot yet understand why they should eat something, depend even more

on these first impressions.

God made a world full of colour, fragrance and flavour. In Psalm 34:8 the psalmist borrows the language of taste to invite people to experience God's goodness: "O taste and see that the LORD is good." The picture works because tasting good things is a real delight. Preparing food that pleases the senses is one way of sharing that delight with children.

Food must look nice

You do not need special equipment to make food look inviting. A few simple habits help:

- **Add colour.** Combine foods of different colours: jollof rice with green peas and carrots, beans with golden fried plantain, a boiled egg beside yam, or a slice of pawpaw or watermelon after the meal. A colourful plate is often a more nourishing plate as well.
- **Serve small portions.** A large heap of food can discourage a small child. Serve a modest amount; the child can ask for more.
- **Keep it simple and tidy.** Place foods neatly side by side rather than mixing everything together, especially for young children, who like to see what they are eating.
- **Serve cleanly.** Use clean plates, cups and spoons. A child's own small plate and cup can make them feel special.
- **Make it fun sometimes.** Cutting bread or fruit into simple shapes, or arranging food in a smiling face, can encourage a reluctant eater.

Food must smell nice

A pleasant aroma from the kitchen – stew cooking, plantain frying, bread warming – builds appetite long before a meal is served. Food that is freshly and carefully cooked usually smells good. On the other hand, food that smells sour, stale or strange may be spoiled and unsafe. Never serve a child food that smells off, even if it seems wasteful to throw it away. A child's health is worth far more than the cost of the food.

Take care also with burning and smoke. Food that has burnt at the bottom of the pot carries a bitter smell and taste that many children dislike. Where possible, feed children in a place that is not filled with smoke from cooking.

Food must taste nice

Taste is where many meals are won or lost. Nigerian cooking is rich in flavour, but food prepared for adults is not always suitable for small children:

- **Go easy on pepper.** Hot pepper can be painful for young children. A practical habit is to dish out the children's portion before adding much pepper to the rest of the pot, and to introduce milder spice gradually as they grow.

- **Limit salt and seasoning cubes.** Small children do not need heavily salted food, and seasoning cubes contain a lot of salt. Use natural flavours such as onions, tomatoes, crayfish and local herbs and spices to make food tasty.
- **Check the temperature.** Food that is too hot can burn a child’s mouth and make them wary of the dish. Let it cool to a comfortable warmth.
- **Check the texture.** Very young children need soft foods that are easy to chew and swallow. As they grow, textures can gradually become firmer.

A calm and happy table

Proverbs 15:17 reminds you that even the best food is spoiled by a bitter atmosphere. A “dinner of herbs” – a plain meal of vegetables – eaten where there is love is better than a “stalled ox”, a fattened animal prepared for a feast, eaten with hatred. The notes on “Eat together” apply this to the whole family; for small children it matters even more, because a child cannot enjoy food that looks, smells and tastes nice while feeling afraid. Young children eat slowly, and many spill, play with their food or lose interest halfway through. This is part of learning, not wickedness. Allow enough time, especially on school mornings – waking a child a little earlier is kinder than hurrying them through breakfast – and seat small children where they can reach their plate comfortably. Praise the child who tries a new food or sits well at the table, and save correction for another moment.

Practical steps

- At your next meal, add one extra colour to your child’s plate – a vegetable or a piece of fruit.
- Serve smaller portions and let children ask for more.
- Set aside the children’s portion before adding extra pepper.
- Reduce the number of seasoning cubes and the amount of salt in family cooking.
- Throw away any food that smells or looks spoiled.
- Allow small children enough time to eat, especially on school mornings, and save correction for another moment.

Questions for reflection

1. How do you respond to food that looks or smells unappealing? How might a child respond?
2. What simple changes could make the food in your home more inviting to children?
3. How can a family enjoy flavourful Nigerian cooking while protecting small children from too much pepper and salt?
4. In the light of Proverbs 15:17, why does a calm atmosphere matter so much for a small child who is learning to eat?

Children eat with their eyes and noses first; a calm and loving table does the rest.

4. Food must be nutritious

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

4. Food must be NUTRITIOUS.

Prove thy servants, I beseech thee, ten days; and let them give us pulse to eat, and water to drink. Then let our countenances be looked upon before thee, and the countenance of the children that eat of the portion of the king's meat: and as thou seest, deal with thy servants. So he consented to them in this matter, and proved them ten days. And at the end of ten days their countenances appeared fairer and fatter in flesh than all the children which did eat the portion of the king's meat.

Daniel 1:12-15 (KJV)

What “nutritious” means

Food is nutritious when it gives the body what it needs to grow, work, repair itself and resist illness. A child can eat until they feel full and still not be well nourished if the food lacks variety. A child who eats only starchy foods day after day may be filled but not properly fed. The leaflet's fourth point reminds parents that looking, smelling and tasting nice is not enough; food must also build a healthy body.

The three food groups

Many Nigerians learned in school that foods can be grouped into three classes according to what they do in the body. This simple way of thinking is a useful guide for planning children's meals:

- **Energy-giving foods** provide fuel for play, learning and growth. Examples include yam, rice, garri, maize (including pap, also called ogi or akamu), plantain, cassava, potatoes and bread.
- **Body-building foods** help the body to grow and repair itself. Examples include beans (and bean dishes such as moi moi and akara), eggs, fish, crayfish, meat, chicken, milk and groundnuts.
- **Protective foods** help the body stay healthy and fight illness. Examples include vegetables such as uguwu, efo and other green leaves, okra, tomatoes and carrots, and fruits such as oranges, pawpaw, bananas, mangoes and guavas.

A well-balanced diet includes foods from all three groups across the day. Many familiar Nigerian meals already combine them: rice and beans served with vegetable stew and fish; yam with egg sauce made with tomatoes and onions; eba or pounded yam with a vegetable soup containing fish or meat; beans and plantain followed by a piece of fruit. Pap on its own is mostly an energy food, but serving it with akara or moi moi adds a body-building food. With a little thought, a family can improve the balance of its meals

without spending much more money.

Fruits and vegetables that are in season are often cheaper and fresher. A handful of ugwu or efo leaves added to a stew, or an orange shared among the children, can make a real difference over time.

Clean water

Water is essential for life and health. Once a child has started eating other foods, offer clean drinking water regularly, especially in hot weather. For a baby in the first six months, exclusive breastfeeding means breast milk only – without extra water – unless a health worker advises otherwise. The water must be safe. Where you are not sure of the source, boil, filter or otherwise treat drinking water, and store it in clean, covered containers. Water, rather than sweet drinks, should be a child's usual drink.

Hygiene in the kitchen and at the table

Nutritious food can still make a child ill if it is not handled cleanly. Simple habits protect the whole family:

- Wash hands with soap and clean water before preparing food, before eating or feeding children, and after using the toilet or changing a nappy.
- Teach children to wash their hands before every meal.
- Wash fruits and vegetables with clean water before eating or cooking them.
- Keep cooked food covered to protect it from flies, dust and pests.
- Store leftovers safely, keep them cool where possible, and reheat them thoroughly before serving.
- Keep plates, cups, spoons, pots and feeding bottles clean.

Limit sugar, sweets and salt

Soft drinks, sweetened juices, sweets, biscuits and other sugary snacks are popular with children and are often given as treats. They need not be forbidden altogether, but taken regularly they can damage teeth, fill children up so that they have little appetite for proper meals, and build a lasting preference for very sweet foods. Offer fruit, or boiled maize and groundnuts for children old enough to chew them safely, or other simple snacks instead. As noted in the previous section, keep salt and seasoning cubes modest in children's food as well.

Babies and small children

Babies and very young children have special needs, and parents should follow the guidance of their clinic or health worker. A few general points are widely recommended:

- **Breastfeeding.** The World Health Organization and other health authorities recommend exclusive breastfeeding – giving the baby breast milk only – for about the first six months of life. After that,

suitable soft foods are introduced alongside breast milk, following the advice of a health worker.

- **No honey for babies under one year.** Honey can cause infant botulism, a serious illness, in babies under one year old, so it should not be given to them in any form – not in food, in drinks or on a dummy.
- **Guard against choking.** Small children can easily choke on hard, small or round foods. Do not give whole groundnuts or hard sweets to young children. Cut food into small, soft pieces, make sure children sit down while eating, and always supervise them at mealtimes. Never force food or drink into a child's mouth.
- **Watch for allergies.** Introduce new foods one at a time and watch for any reaction, such as a rash, swelling, vomiting or difficulty breathing. Swelling of the face or any difficulty breathing needs urgent medical help.

A biblical picture

Daniel 1 tells how Daniel and his companions, taken as captives to Babylon, asked not to eat the king's rich food or drink his wine. They requested "pulse" – simple food grown from seed, such as vegetables and grains – and water for a ten-day test. At the end of the test they looked healthier and better nourished than the young men who ate the king's portion. The main lesson of the passage is Daniel's faithfulness to God, and it is not a diet plan or a medical rule. Yet it offers a helpful picture: simple, wholesome food received with a faithful heart can nourish the body well, and rich or expensive food is not necessarily better.

Throughout this section the guidance is general, and it is not medical advice. If you are concerned about your child's diet, growth or health, speak to a doctor, nurse or other qualified health worker.

Practical steps

- Look at yesterday's meals and check whether your child ate something from each of the three food groups.
- Add one protective food – a vegetable or a fruit – to your child's diet each day.
- Make water your child's usual drink, and keep sugary drinks for occasional treats.
- Put a hand-washing routine in place before every meal.
- Check that your home's drinking water is safe and stored in clean, covered containers.
- Keep whole groundnuts, hard sweets and other choking hazards out of the reach of small children.

Questions for reflection

1. Which of the three food groups is most often missing from the meals in your home?
2. How can a family with limited money still provide nourishing meals for children?

3. Which hygiene habits in your kitchen could be improved?
4. What does the story in Daniel 1 teach, and what does it not teach, about food?

A full stomach is not always a well-fed body; aim for variety, cleanliness and care.

5. Give children food they like to eat

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

5. Give children food they like to eat.

And, ye fathers, provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord.

Ephesians 6:4 (KJV)

Why liking matters

The last point of the leaflet is very practical: food only nourishes a child if the child actually eats it. A parent may prepare the most nutritious meal, but if the child refuses it day after day, it does little good. Giving children food they like to eat is not spoiling them. It recognises that children are persons with real tastes and preferences, and that a happy eater is more likely to be a well-fed child.

Luke 2:52 records that the boy Jesus “increased in wisdom and stature, and in favour with God and man.” Growth in stature – the growth of the body – is named alongside wisdom and favour. Caring for a child’s body, including their enjoyment of food, is part of caring for the whole child.

Balancing liking with nourishment

This point must be read together with the fourth. Children should be given food they like, but not only the foods they like. If left entirely to choose, many children would eat sweets, biscuits and soft drinks all day. A helpful balance is this: parents decide which healthy foods are offered and when meals take place, and children are allowed some say in how much they eat of what is offered. This respects the child without handing over the whole menu.

Offer new foods many times

Children are often cautious about new foods. A child who refuses a vegetable today may accept it next week or next month; children often need to be offered a new food many times before they accept it. So do not give up after one refusal, and do not quickly decide, “My child does not eat beans.” Offer a small amount again on another day, without pressure. Let the child touch it, smell it or taste a tiny bit. Over time, familiarity often turns refusal into acceptance.

Include a familiar food

When you introduce something new, place it beside at least one familiar food the child already likes. A child who sees their favourite fried plantain on the plate will come to the table happily, and may be willing to try the unfamiliar vegetable beside it. In this way each plate can hold something the child enjoys and something that helps them grow.

Involve children in food

Children are more willing to eat food they have helped to choose or prepare. Take older children to the market and let them choose between two vegetables or two fruits. Let them help with safe tasks suited to their age, such as washing vegetables, picking stones out of beans, stirring a cold mixture or setting the table. Keep young children well away from fire, hot oil, boiling water and sharp knives. Talking about where food comes from, and thanking God for it together, also helps children value what they eat.

Parents show the way

Children copy what they see. If parents refuse vegetables, drink soft drinks at every meal or complain about food, children are likely to do the same. When children see their parents enjoying fruit, vegetables and water, and giving thanks for simple meals, they learn that these things are normal and good. Eating together as a family, as the marriage leaflet encourages, is one of the best ways to model healthy eating.

Do not use food as a bribe or a punishment

Ephesians 6:4 tells fathers not to provoke their children to wrath, but to bring them up in the nurture and admonition – the loving training and instruction – of the Lord. Mealtimes can easily become a battlefield that provokes anger and fear. Avoid forcing children to clear the plate, threatening them, or pushing food into their mouths. Avoid using sweets as a reward for eating vegetables, which teaches children that vegetables are a punishment and sweets are the prize. Above all, never withhold food from a child as a punishment. Food is a gift from God and a basic need, not a tool of discipline.

When to see a health worker

Some children are simply choosy eaters, and this often improves with patience. But certain signs should never be ignored. Take your child to a clinic, primary health centre, doctor or other qualified health worker if your child shows any of these signs:

- Losing weight, or looking thinner than before.
- Falling sick often.
- Swollen feet.
- Not growing well, or falling behind in growth.
- Refusing food and drink for a long time, or seeming unusually weak or tired.

Many clinics check children's growth by weighing and measuring them regularly. Make use of these services, and seek help early rather than waiting until a child is very ill.

Practical steps

- Ask each child to name two or three healthy foods they enjoy, and build some of the week's meals around them.
- Put one familiar food your child likes on every plate, beside anything new.
- When a food is refused, offer a small amount again on another day, without pressure or comment.
- Let older children choose between two vegetables or two fruits at the market, and give them a safe kitchen task suited to their age.
- Eat the same healthy foods yourself, and let your children see you enjoying them.
- Stop using sweets as a reward for eating, and never withhold a meal as a punishment.
- Take young children for regular growth checks at the clinic, and seek help early if any of the warning signs above appear.

A family prayer over meals

Taken together, the two leaflets point to one picture: a family gathered around the table, thankful to God and caring for one another. You may use this prayer, or your own words, before a family meal:

Heavenly Father, thank you for this food and for the hands that prepared it. Thank you for our home and for each person at this table. Bless this meal to our bodies, and help us to love one another in word and in deed. Provide for those who have no food today, and make us generous to share. In the name of Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen.

Questions for reflection

1. Which foods do your children most enjoy, and how can you combine them with foods that help them grow?
2. How do you usually respond when a child refuses a new food? What might you do differently?
3. In what ways could your children help with choosing or preparing food?
4. Why is it important never to use food as a bribe or a punishment?
5. Looking back over the whole booklet, what one change will you make to show love more clearly in your home?

Offer good food with patience and love, and your children will learn to receive it with thanks.